AIIMS RANSOMWARE ATTACK

THE OTHER KIND OF VIRUS

The ransomware attack on AIIMS in the national capital last month is not an isolated one. As hospitals go digital post-pandemic, there is a rising trend of cyberattacks on healthcare facilities globally

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Graphic by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

Last week, as cyber security analysts were trawling the darker reaches of the Internet for signs of any data from the cyberattack on the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) in New Delhi, they instead came upon a screenshot of hospital records from another hack. This database, suspected to have come from a hospital in Tiruppur, Tamil Nadu, and dating back 15 years, was being advertised for sale on popular cybercrime forums at a starting price of $100.

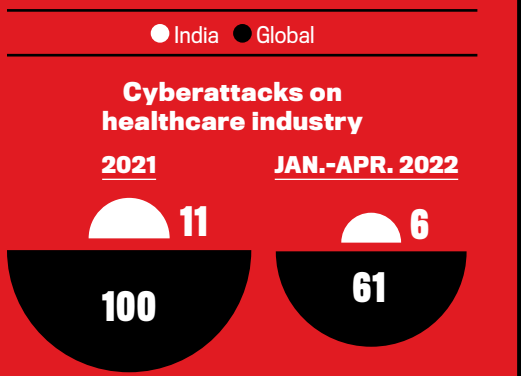
Since the pandemic, cyberattacks on healthcare facilities are on the rise as hospitals—like other critical services—are rapidly going digital. Incidentally, the November 23 ransomware attack on AIIMS came just weeks after the institute announced its plan to go paperless from January 1, 2023. As it turned out, the cyberattack crippled its IT infrastructure, forcing AIIMS to revert to manual billing, report generation and appointment scheduling.

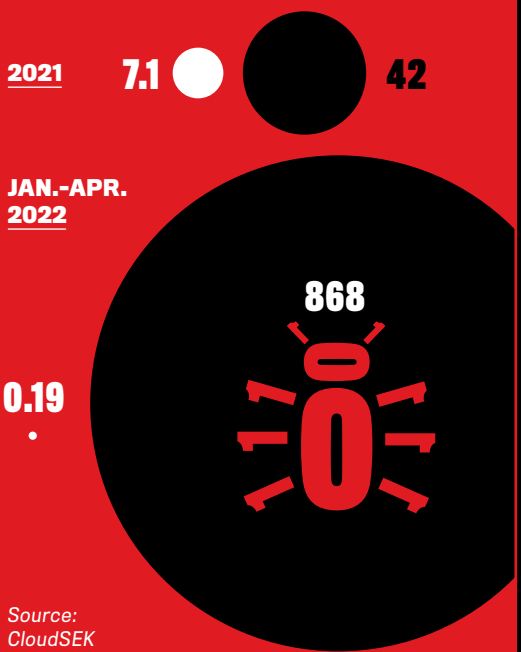
"Only when the cyber security is weak do you see an elevated number of [cyberattack] incidents," says Rahul Sasi, founder of CloudSEK, a Bengaluru-based company that uses artificial intelligence to predict cyber threats. E-crime groups, he says, are typically scanning a range of computer systems, trying to access data they can resell in different marketplaces. "Since the start of Covid, health data has become the main target," adds Sunny Nehra, a Gurugram-based cyber security consultant who has worked with two hospitals in Chennai and Bengaluru that suffered attacks in the past couple of months.

NASSCOM-linked think-tank Data Security Council of India (DSCI) has also been working on cybersecurity awareness among healthcare institutions. "Until now, we used to hear of big 'exploitation' happening in other parts of the globe. But it's now happening around us," says Vinayak Godse, CEO of DSCI. According to CloudSEK, the US, India, France, China and Italy were the top five countries targeted in cyberattacks in healthcare industry last year.

A SPAMDEMIC?

In 2021, India recorded the second highest number of healthcare sector cyberattacks after the US





Source: CloudSEK

WHAT IS RANSOMWARE?

- Ransomware is a malicious software used to encrypt data on a system following which attackers demand ransom in return for the decryption key
- According to Indian Computer Emergency Response Team, India has recorded 51 per cent rise in ransomware incidents in the first half of 2022 as compared to 2021
- A majority of the attacks were on data centres/ IT/ ITeS sector, followed by manufacturing and finance